

NotchItUp

Category: Forensics

Subcategory: ETL / Raw File Analysis

Difficulty: medium

File: Challenge.raw

Flag: OBV{7F2A_4C91_BLACK_VAULT}

Objective

Analyze the provided Challenge.raw artifact, identify the hidden payload, decode it, and recover the OBV{...} flag.

Intended Solve

1. Extract the challenge

The challenge is provided as a .7z archive. First, extract it: **7z x Challenge_NotchItUp.7z**

Why?

7z x extracts the contents of the archive while preserving the original file data. After extraction, we get the main challenge artifact: **Challenge.raw**

2. Identify the file

Check what type of file we're dealing with: **file Challenge.raw**

Output: **Challenge.raw: Windows Event Trace Log**

Why?

The .raw extension doesn't tell us what the file actually contains. file examines the file's contents and identifies it as a Windows Event Trace Log (ETL), indicating that the challenge involves analyzing system/event data.

3. Search for the hidden payload

Instead of searching for the complete OBV{} flag, search for the marker:

```
grep -aobF 'Payload=' Challenge.raw
```

Why?

- **-a** → treat the binary file as text
- **-b** → show the byte offset
- **-o** → show the matching text
- **-F** → search for the exact string

Output: 1610547201:Payload=

This tells us that a **Payload=** entry exists inside the raw artifact.

4. Read the payload

```
strings -a Challenge.raw | grep -F 'Payload='
```

Why?

strings extracts readable text from binary data. We then use **grep** to display only the line containing **Payload=**.

Output:

```
Payload=T0JWezdGMkFfNEM5MV9CTEFDS19WQVVMVH0=
```

The value after **Payload=** looks like Base64.

5. Decode the payload

```
echo 'T0JWezdGMkFfNEM5MV9CTEFDS19WQVVMVH0=' | base64 -d
```

Why?

base64 -d decodes the Base64-encoded payload back into its original text.

Output:

```
OBV{7F2A_4C91_BLACK_VAULT}
```

Note:

The flag is hidden inside the raw challenge artifact as an encoded payload. Players must locate the **Payload=** entry, identify the Base64-encoded value, and decode it to obtain the final flag.